

German union aims for breakthrough at Tesla Berlin plant



FILE PHOTO: A Tesla logo is pictured at a Tesla dealership, after Tesla, Inc. released its financial results for the first quarter of 2025, in Berlin, Germany April 23, 2025. REUTERS/Annegret Hilse/File Photo · Reuters

By Rachel More

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BERLIN, March 4 (Reuters) - Germany's top industrial union is fighting for more influence at [Tesla](#)'s gigafactory outside Berlin, where staff are voting for a new works council after a campaign marked by mud-slinging and legal challenges.

Voting began on Monday at Tesla's Gruenheide plant, the U.S. electric car maker's only European production site, with results expected later Wednesday.

How do German works councils function in labor relations?

What is IG Metall's strategy to gain control at Tesla?

Why is this election significant for Tesla's operations?

The current council is dominated by non-union members. The IG Metall union is fielding 116 candidates in a bid to win a simple majority - 19 of 37 seats. The union secured 16 in the last election two years ago, when the council had 39 seats.

IG Metall has accused management of stoking anti-union sentiment. Plant director Andre Thierig has countered that the union is focused solely on boosting IG Metall membership.

"We are very satisfied with our election campaign. We are running with a great team and our issues are clearly striking a chord with our colleagues," IG Metall's lead candidate Laura Arndt said in a statement to Reuters.

Works councils, elected by staff, are a cornerstone of German labour relations, representing employees in talks with management.

IG Metall dominates councils across German carmakers - including Volkswagen, BMW and Mercedes - but remains the underdog at Tesla, whose CEO Elon Musk is outspoken in his criticism of unions.

Tensions peaked in February when Tesla accused an IG Metall trade unionist of secretly filming a works council meeting and filed a criminal complaint.

IG Metall dismissed the allegation as a "calculated lie".

(Reporting by Rachel More and Christina Amann. Editing by Mark Potter)

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